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BUSINESS ON LINE

Initially subscription driven, marriage portals are now branching out into multiple avenues to boost revenues

100 odd matrimonial sites exist in India

50% growth rate in marriage site sector

The year was 1997. Anupam Mittal, CMD, People Group, the company that owns shaadi.com was doing his MBA at Boston. A short trip to India opened his eyes to new business potential. And shaadi.com was born. Today the site claims to be the largest matrimonial site with over 10 million members. "There was a lot of buzz about the Internet in India around that time," says Mittal. "The country was opening up and changing dramatically." Meantime, Janakiraman Murugavel, founder of bharatmatrimony was busy handing out fliers advertising his portal, sysindia.com (a community site for NRIs) at South Asian events in the US. He soon realised that the most visited segment of the site was its matrimonial listings. Bharatmatrimony.com was born in 2002 in India. It now has over nine million members in 24 countries.

Initially the revenue models were subscription-driven, but as footfalls started rising they gradually learnt "when" and "how" to get users to pay. For the trusted portals, a three-month stint can be an affordable Rs 500, but it's more likely to be between Rs 1,300 and Rs 2,200. A six-month spell ranges between Rs 2,000 and Rs 4,000, and year-long privileges costing around Rs 4,000-5,000. Many subscribers go for the packages promising sharper and better results. If a Classic Package for three months costs Rs 1,590, a Classic Plus Package goes up to Rs 1,990, and a Classic Super Package up to Rs 2,290.

But it's in this need to stand out that online dating services find their greatest business opportunity. Most charge extra for letting users post multiple pictures with ads, giving ads prominent placement, instant messaging sessions or collect calls to their members. Today the revenue model for most matrimonial sites is a mix of subscription and advertising. But both the groups are spreading out in different directions (often offline) in their quest for growth. An Ahmedabad-based service-provider, klassicmatch.com, promises to deliver sons and daughters of "vips" for Rs 50,000 only. They create PowerPoint presentations and tour around the country, calling on "appropriate" families. By the way, you may just have to cough up some "appreciation" charges, if you manage to land a groovy match. A brave new world, indeed.



PIONEERS: Mittal (top); Murugavel

unwillingness to undo ties with traditions: If 64 per cent men in Delhi favour inter-caste marriage, 59 per cent desire fair women. If 62 per cent Mumbai women want to work after marriage, a mere 37 per cent are open to inter-caste marriage. In Bangalore, 54 per cent prefer working wives while Pune girls want the big-city life with 88 per cent asking for metro men. In Chennai, 88 per cent men seek educated brides, yet only 29 per cent want working wives.

Personal choice is now the new mantra on online mating. Today, it's all about taking over from parents and finding one's soulmate. Sudharshan Murthy's parents wanted a girl from the same caste, while for Shweta's parents caste was not an issue. A project manager with Colliers International, Murthy's family is based in Bangalore, while Shweta is from Kolkata. They met each other on the Net and love blossomed. But, Shweta, a web designer had hearing impairment and lots of "ifs" and "buts" about relationship with a "normal" man. "To convince her and to communicate better, I started learning sign language," recalls Murthy. It took a lot of hard work to convince the parents," he says, but they finally gave in, and are happy they did. Sudarshan and Shweta welcome the "new mind-scape" amongst a lot of young people they see around them.

For Swamy and her liberal parents—a retired civil servant and a banker based in Jabalpur in Madhya Pradesh—life has become simpler ever since the rules got reversed. These days, she comes back from work, scans the resumes that her marriage portal chooses according to her parameters, picks some, ignores others, talks to a few, meets up with the rest and finally informs her parents about her shortlist. That way she gets the upper edge in her own mate selection. "It's as if I've opened up a vital window on my life," she says. "Choosing a mate, getting to know a person not just by their cv, but their attitude and values is an exciting process. It's like giving romance a chance in a union of convenience and that's cool with me," she says, the laughter in her voice conveying the sense of adventure and fulfillment. ■